When the Dog Has Inertia: Feedback Equilibria, Lost Potential and Equilibrium Selection in an Influence Game

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Abstract

Two players repeatedly pull a shared point, the dog, toward their own houses. Without inertia the game is an instance of the Battling Influencers Game, an exact potential game (Wu et al., 2025). We study what survives when the dog keeps part of its position each round. We prove that holding the one-shot equilibrium actions is a Markov-perfect equilibrium if and only if each player's slack beyond the dog is at least w0(1 - g w0)/(1 - g w0^2), where w0 is the inertia and g the discount, and we give an explicit piecewise-affine feedback equilibrium whenever the houses lie on either side of the dog. The condition extends to many houses, where the admissible inertia shrinks like 1/N. We show that the dynamic game is not a Markov potential game once policies react to the dog. For learning, we find that policy-gradient self-play from random starts learns to hold the one-shot actions, which is exploitable off the equilibrium path, and that on the potential's flat direction learning is a random walk stopped by the action box, so which of two mirror equilibria wins is a fair coin.

1. Introduction

Influence games, in which agents with fixed targets push a shared quantity, are a clean testbed for multi-agent learning: the static game has a potential, its equilibria are computable, and its learning dynamics can be checked exactly. The Battling Influencers Game proves the potential structure and characterizes pure equilibria of the one-shot game (Wu et al., 2025). Real influence is persistent, though: opinions, prices or a dog on a leash keep part of their state. This paper asks what the static results imply once the shared point has inertia, and what policy-gradient learners find. Our contributions, each verified computationally in the accompanying repository:

- A necessary and sufficient condition for the one-shot equilibrium to remain Markov-perfect under inertia (Proposition 1), and an explicit piecewise-affine feedback equilibrium when it does not (Proposition 2), both with proofs and checked against an exact dynamic program.
- The extension of the condition to many houses, where the static outcome is the generalized median of the average voting rule (Renault and Trannoy, 2005), and the finding that the admissible inertia shrinks like 1/N.
- A concrete check that the dynamic game is not a Markov potential game, although every state game is a potential game.
- Two learning findings: self-play misses the feedback equilibrium, and selection along a flat potential is a random walk stopped by the action box. The second corrects an earlier small-sample result of ours.

The static potential structure and the general fact that stage-wise potential games need not be Markov potential games are known; we claim novelty only for the results above, for this game, as far as the literature we checked goes.

2. Related work

Potential games go back to Monderer and Shapley (1996); noisy learning in them selects potential maximizers (Blume, 1993). The Battling Influencers Game (Wu et al., 2025) is the static game studied here. Markov potential games (Leonardos et al., ICLR 2022) give convergence of independent policy gradient, and a Markov game whose stage games are potential games need not be one; a continuous-state counterexample to sufficient conditions appears in arXiv 2405.08206. Potential differential games reduce to one optimal-control problem in open loop (Kavuncu, Yaraneri and Mehr, RSS 2021). Feedback equilibria of constrained linear-quadratic games are piecewise affine over polyhedral regions (arXiv 2001.01826; Benenati and Belgioioso, arXiv 2512.07749); Proposition 2 is an explicit instance with a proof specific to this game. The average voting rule's equilibrium outcome is a generalized median (Renault and Trannoy, 2005). Policy gradient provably finds Nash equilibria of unconstrained linear-quadratic games (Hambly, Xu and Yang, JMLR 2023); equilibrium selection by multi-agent policy gradient is studied in finite games (ICML 2026, arXiv 2605.18078).

3. Model

Two players choose a_red and a_blue in the unit square. The dog moves to x' = w0 x + (1 - w0)(w a_red + (1 - w) a_blue), with inertia w0 in [0, 1) and red's weight w in (0, 1), and player i receives -||x' - h_i||^2, discounted by g in [0, 1). Rewards, dynamics and the action box all separate by coordinate, so the game splits into two independent one-dimensional games, and a profile is a feedback (Markov-perfect) equilibrium iff it is one in each coordinate. With w0 = 0 this is the one-shot game, with potential Phi = -||d||^2 + 2 w h_red . a_red + 2 (1 - w) h_blue . a_blue, where d = w a_red + (1 - w) a_blue. Let (a_red*, a_blue*) be the one-shot equilibrium, d* its dog, k = (1 - g w0^2)/(1 - g w0) and T_i = d* + k (h_i - d*) player i's target.

4. Feedback equilibria with inertia

Proposition 1. Holding the one-shot actions at every dog position is a feedback equilibrium iff every player at an edge of the box has slack s >= rho(w0, g) = w0 (1 - g w0)/(1 - g w0^2), with s = (h - d*)/(1 - d*) at the top edge and (d* - h)/d* at the bottom, and, when w0 > 0, no one-shot action is strictly inside the box.

Proposition 2. If the houses lie on either side of the dog (h_blue <= w <= h_red after relabeling), the policy in which each player aims the next dog position at its target T_i, as far as its own weight allows, with the other at its one-shot action, is a feedback equilibrium for every w0 in [0, 1) and g in [0, 1). It is piecewise affine in the dog's position and equals the one-shot profile wherever holding is optimal.

Both proofs use the one-shot deviation principle. Under holding, a player's one-round objective is a concave quadratic in the next dog position peaked at T_i, which gives Proposition 1. For Proposition 2, a contraction argument shows the one-round objective under the policy is single-peaked at T_i on all of [0, 1], so the clipped target is a best reply. Full proofs are in docs/INERTIA_PROOFS.md.

Checks. An exact dynamic program (Nash value iteration, 401 positions by 101 actions per coordinate) agrees with both propositions to one action-grid step in every coordinate of five house setups at w0 = 0.3, 0.6 and 0.9. On 200 random one-coordinate games, with the deviation gain computed by simulating the dog rather than on a grid:

One-shot equilibrium	Games	Explicit policy is an equilibrium (gain < 1e-9)	Largest one-round gain	Holding is Markov-perfect
straddle	77	77 of 77	0.0e+00	30 of 77
interior	123	70 of 123	2.3e-02	0 of 123

Proposition 2 holds in all 77 straddling games, and holding alone in 30 of them, as Proposition 1 predicts. With an interior one-shot action the policy is an equilibrium in only 70 of 123 games: the interior player pushes at an edge off its house, the dog returns faster than under holding, and the other player's best target moves. That case, and uniqueness, are open.

Many houses. With N players the one-shot dog is the generalized median of the average voting rule, at most one player (the pivot) is inside the box, and Proposition 1 holds verbatim. Drawing N houses from Beta(2, 5) with equal weights (200 draws per N, discount 0.9):

Houses N	One-shot dog: mean (sd); limit 0.339	No pivot inside (limit 0.34)	Largest inertia: mean	N times it, median when no pivot
2	0.368 (0.115)	0.20	0.0399	0.27
4	0.340 (0.090)	0.28	0.0357	0.43
8	0.340 (0.055)	0.34	0.0206	0.27
16	0.337 (0.038)	0.29	0.0111	0.45
32	0.340 (0.028)	0.35	0.0058	0.33
64	0.341 (0.019)	0.32	0.0024	0.32
128	0.339 (0.013)	0.34	0.0012	0.34
256	0.340 (0.010)	0.34	0.0007	0.33
512	0.340 (0.007)	0.28	0.0003	0.43
1024	0.340 (0.005)	0.32	0.0002	0.35

A pivot inside the box (about two draws in three) rules holding out at any inertia; otherwise the largest admissible inertia scales like 0.35/N. With many houses the static equilibrium is almost never a feedback equilibrium.

5. The dynamic game is not a Markov potential game

In a Markov potential game, every 4-cycle of unilateral policy changes sums to zero. Exact values from the starting dog position of one setup:

Inertia w0	Policies that ignore the dog	Policies that react to the dog
0.0	+6.7e-15	+7.90
0.3	+3.1e-15	+7.12
0.6	+1.8e-15	+5.63
0.9	+5.6e-15	+1.85

With policies that ignore the dog, the dynamic game remains a potential game at any inertia (open loop); with policies that react to it, it is not, even at w0 = 0. The convergence theory of independent policy gradient in Markov potential games therefore does not cover the feedback play studied below.

6. Learning

Self-play misses the feedback equilibrium. We train self-play from uniformly random dog positions and score the learned mean policy by its feedback exploitability: the largest and mean gain, over dog positions and players, from a one-round deviation followed by the learned policy, with the dog simulated exactly. Every feedback equilibrium scores 0, so the score does not assume uniqueness.

Setting	Policy	Runs	Largest one-round gain: median (range)	Mean one-round gain: median
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	Proposition 2	1	0.0000	0.0000
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	hold the one-shot actions	1	0.0756	0.0114
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	REINFORCE	5	0.1537 (0.1156 to 0.6714)	0.0275
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	A2C	5	0.0756 (0.0755 to 0.0759)	0.0115
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	PPO	5	0.0756 (0.0756 to 0.4599)	0.0115
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	REINFORCE, Beta policy	5	0.0900 (0.0855 to 0.1287)	0.0247
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	A2C, Beta policy	5	0.0854 (0.0813 to 0.0891)	0.0222
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	PPO, Beta policy	5	0.0991 (0.0700 to 0.4077)	0.0323
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	A2C, 15000 episodes	3	0.0756 (0.0756 to 0.0756)	0.0114
setup 3, w0 = 0.6	A2C, Beta policy, 15000 episodes	3	0.0791 (0.0776 to 0.0798)	0.0150
setup 5, w0 = 0.9	Proposition 2	1	0.0000	0.0000
setup 5, w0 = 0.9	hold the one-shot actions	1	0.2084	0.0397
setup 5, w0 = 0.9	REINFORCE	5	0.2014 (0.1506 to 0.3832)	0.0337
setup 5, w0 = 0.9	A2C	5	0.2084 (0.2084 to 0.2084)	0.0397
setup 5, w0 = 0.9	PPO	5	0.2084 (0.2084 to 0.2084)	0.0397

A2C and PPO learn to hold the one-shot actions at every position, which is unexploitable on the equilibrium path and exploitable off it, and this survives five times longer training, a non-saturating Beta policy and a setting with 3.5 times the off-path incentive. REINFORCE does not do better. Low on-path exploitability therefore does not certify a feedback equilibrium. Why learners miss it is open; small off-path gains relative to gradient noise is one untested explanation.

Selection on a flat potential. When the houses share a coordinate, the potential is flat along a continuum of equilibria. REINFORCE self-play, 50 seeds per initial exploration noise:

Initial noise (std)	red top, blue bottom	red bottom, blue top	both at y = 0.5	other	p (mirror images equally likely)
0.14	19 of 50	22 of 50	0 of 50	9 of 50	0.76
0.37	31 of 50	19 of 50	0 of 50	0 of 50	0.12
0.61 (default)	31 of 50	19 of 50	0 of 50	0 of 50	0.12
1.00	30 of 50	20 of 50	0 of 50	0 of 50	0.20

No run ends at the interior equilibrium, and which mirror image wins is consistent with a fair coin; an earlier 10-seed analysis of ours had suggested that the noise level flips it, which did not replicate. Two ablations show why:

Policy mean in y, actions and dog	red top, blue bottom	red bottom, blue top	both at y = 0.5	other	Red's final y: quartiles	Red's y outside [0, 1]
sigmoid, clipped (default)	31 of 50	19 of 50	0 of 50	0 of 50	0.00 / 0.99 / 1.00	0 of 50
sigmoid, not clipped	20 of 50	21 of 50	0 of 50	9 of 50	0.03 / 0.64 / 0.97	0 of 50
linear, not clipped	17 of 50	20 of 50	0 of 50	13 of 50	-2.26 / 0.33 / 1.29	38 of 50

The expected gradient along the flat direction is zero but noisy, so the policy means random-walk; with an unbounded mean the walk leaves the box, and the default sigmoid policy stops it at the edges. Clipped exploration noise also makes the averaged potential dip at the interior, pushing either way equally.

7. Discussion and limits

The static potential structure does not carry over to feedback play, but the static equilibrium does survive on the equilibrium path, and exactly characterizes where it fails off the path. The feedback equilibrium is explicit when the houses straddle the dog; learners nevertheless converge to the static profile. Limits: the proofs are ours and not refereed; Proposition 2 excludes interior one-shot actions; learning results use one game, a few settings and five seeds per setting; and the noisy continuous-time version of the game, which needs an action cost for a Riccati benchmark, is not studied.

References

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